

account for some of the features of the OS, although it is not even close to as restrictive as Windows 8.

If it is just a matter of not wanting to associate your primary Microsoft account with your OS install, you can create a separate account for this purpose. So, if you are OK with a Microsoft account, what all you get?

A Microsoft account is essentially what used to be Windows Live, or Microsoft Live. It is a number of Microsoft services wrapped up into one.

If you have a Microsoft account if you have used Hotmail, or SkyDrive. A Microsoft account will give you access to all these Microsoft services.

If you make a Microsoft account for use with Windows 8 it will include access to SkyDrive, with 7GB free online storage, and a Hotmail or Outlook account for email. For Windows 8 you will also need it for the Windows Store and to install Modern UI apps.

There are some benefits you get from using your Microsoft account to sign into Windows rather than a regular Windows account. The first benefit, and one we have already mentioned before, is that it will synchronise a lot of your personalisations and settings across multiple computers. This is understandably useless if you have just one computer.

Even third party app developers can tap into SkyDrive APIs and synchronise their data using it. So your eBook reading app, could keep the same eBooks on all computers along with maintaining information about what page you are on in each book, browsers can ensure that your browsing sessions (tabs, history and even cookies) are in sync across devices.

Another benefit is that this automatically keeps you signed in into all apps that need a Microsoft ID. Otherwise you have to individually sign into the SkyDrive app, the Games app, the Mail app, the messenger app, the calendar app etc.

This even automatically signs you into Microsoft services in Internet Explorer, and can be used by other third party apps for ID as well.

Still having a Microsoft account connected to your local account is not necessary, although having a Microsoft account probably is, if you want to install any Modern UI apps at all.

The Windows 8 Store

So Microsoft finally has a store for Windows, and supposedly only Modern UI applications can only be installed from there.

This is true for the most part, but there are minor exceptions. For example, the Windows store does list desktop applications, but it doesn't sell them,